ROS 2 Development Workflow

This explains how to contribute to the ROS 2 project, from `git` basics to build, test, CI, and review.

Reference:

- ROS 2 Developer Guide
- Contributing to ROS 2 Documentation

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Agenda

- General `git` workflow
- ROS 2 branches
- Repository checkout & full source build
- `colcon` build and tests
- Jenkins ROS 2 CI
- Issue / PR templates, QA & support
- AI-assisted contribution policy
- Contributing to ROS 2 documentation



Two Contribution Tracks

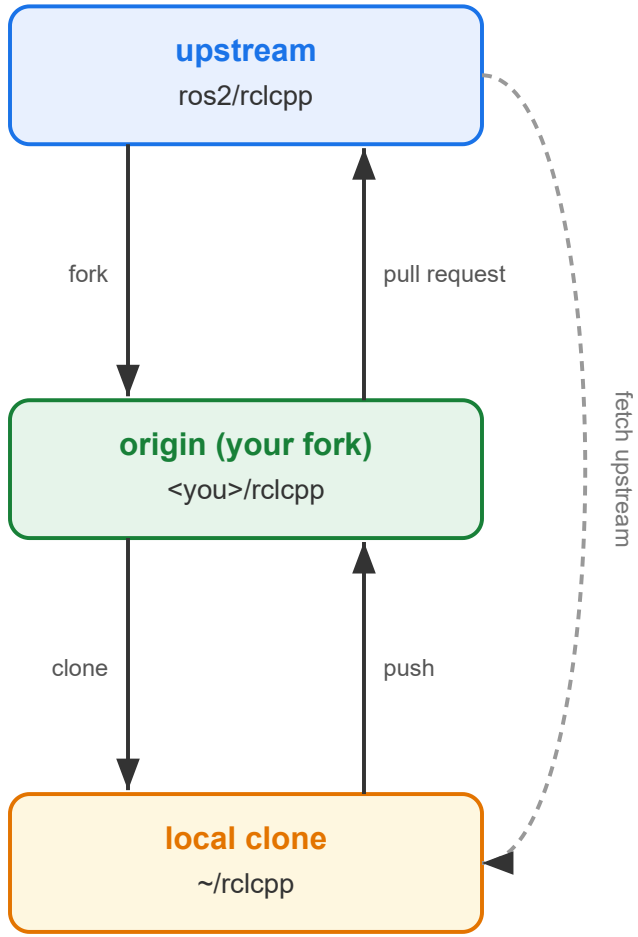
	Core Libraries	Documentation
Where	github.com/ros2	ros2/ros2_documentation
Language	C++ / Python / CMake	reStructuredText / Markdown
Guide	Developer Guide	Contributing To Docs
Build	`colcon build` / `cmake`	`sphinx` / `make html`

Both share the **same** `git` **/ PR / DCO / review** workflow.

General `git` Workflow — Fork & Clone

ROS 2 uses the **fork-and-pull-request** model on GitHub. Fork the target repository into your namespace, then clone. Keep `upstream` as the source of truth; `origin` is your fork.

```
# fork on GitHub UI first
git clone git@github.com:<you>/rclcpp.git
cd rclcpp
git remote add upstream git@github.com:ros2/rclcpp.git
git fetch upstream
```



General `git` Workflow — Branch & Commit

Create a **topic branch** off the correct base branch (usually `rolling`).

```
git checkout -b fix/executor-deadlock upstream/rolling
```

Write focused commits, one logical change per commit. **Sign off every commit** — the Developer Certificate of Origin (DCO) is mandatory.

```
git commit -s -m "Fix deadlock in MultiThreadedExecutor"
```

General `git` Workflow — Pull Request Flow

1. Push the topic branch to your fork.
2. Open a PR against `ros2/<repo>` `rolling`.
3. Fill the PR template; link related issues.
4. Green **CI + DCO + at least one maintainer approval**.
5. Squash / rebase as requested, then a maintainer merges.

```
you:fix/... ──PR──▶ ros2/repo:rolling ──(review + CI)──▶ merge
```

ROS 2 Branches — `rolling` is the trunk

`rolling` is the continuously developed development distribution. All new features and fixes land on `rolling` **first**. Named distribution branches are cut from `rolling` at release.

Branch	Purpose
`rolling`	active development, target of most PRs
`lyrical` / `kilted` / `jazzy` / `humble`	released distributions (maintenance)

ROS 2 Branches — Backporting via Mergifyio

- Fixes needed on released distros are **backported** from `rolling`.
- Label the PR (e.g. `backport-jazzy`) so **Mergify** automates a cherry-pick PR.
- Backports must respect REP 2000 API/ABI stability rules for released distros.

```
git cherry-pick -x <sha>   # -x records the source commit
```

Repository Checkout — `vcstool` & `.repos`

- ROS 2 is **many repositories** orchestrated by a `.repos` file.
- Use `vcstool` to import the whole source tree.

```
mkdir -p ~/ros2_ws/src && cd ~/ros2_ws
wget https://raw.githubusercontent.com/ros2/ros2/rolling/ros2.repos
vcs import src < ros2.repos
vcs pull src        # keep everything up to date
```

Full Source Build — Dependencies

- Resolve system dependencies with **`rosdep`**.

```
sudo rosdep init && rosdep update
rosdep install --from-paths src --ignore-src -y \
  --rosdistro rolling
```

- Install build tools: `colcon`, `vcstool`, compilers, `python3-*` deps.
- See the source install guide.

`colcon` Build

- `colcon` is the meta-build tool for ROS 2 workspaces.

```
colcon build --symlink-install \
  --cmake-args -DCMAKE_BUILD_TYPE=RelWithDebInfo
```

- Useful options:
  - `--packages-select` / `--packages-up-to` — build a subset.
  - `--symlink-install` — edit Python/resources without rebuilding.
  - `--event-handlers console_direct+` — stream build output.

`colcon` Test

```
colcon test --packages-select rclcpp
colcon test-result --all --verbose
```

- Test frameworks in ROS 2:
  - **C++**: `gtest` / `gmock`
  - **Python**: `pytest`
  - **Launch/integration**: `launch_testing`
- Every behavioral change should ship with a **regression test**.

Code Style & Linters

- ROS 2 enforces style automatically via `ament_lint`.
  - C++: `ament_uncrustify`, `ament_cpplint`, `ament_cppcheck`
  - Python: `ament_flake8`, `ament_pep257`
  - `ament_copyright`, `ament_xmllint`
- Follow the ROS 2 Code Style (based on Google C++ Style with ROS additions).

```
ament_uncrustify --reformat src/rclcpp
```

Jenkins ROS 2 CI — ci.ros2.org

- ROS 2 CI runs on a **Jenkins build farm** across platforms.
- Coverage: **Linux, Linux-aarch64, Windows, RHEL**.
- Nightly jobs build & test all of `rolling` from source.
- Per-PR jobs validate a change against the full stack before merge.

Jenkins CI — Running a PR Job

- Maintainers trigger a CI run scoped to your PR packages.

```
Test with --packages-above-and-dependencies rclcpp
Job: ci_launcher → Linux / Linux-aarch64 / Windows / RHEL
```

- The green/red result is posted back; **all targets must pass**.
- You can reproduce a target locally with the same `colcon` invocation.

Issue Templates

- Repos ship issue templates under `.github/ISSUE_TEMPLATE/` .
- Provide a **minimal reproducible example**:
  - ROS 2 distro & OS, RMW implementation
  - Install method (binary / source)
  - Exact steps, expected vs. actual behavior
- Search existing issues first; discuss the approach **before** a large PR.

PR Template & Review

- Fill the PR template: **what changed, why, how tested**.
- Checklist typically covers: tests added, docs updated, DCO signed.
- Review expectations:
  - Respond to reviewer comments directly and technically.
  - Keep the PR focused; avoid unrelated churn.
  - Rebase, don't merge `rolling` into your branch repeatedly.

AI-Assisted Contribution Policy

Guidelines for AI-Assisted Contributions in the ROS Project

- You **may** use AI tools to build, explore, and understand software.
- Extends the OSRF Policy on Generative Tools with quality & behavioral rules.
- Core idea: **do not shift verification work onto maintainers.**

AI Policy — The Rules

- **Author Ownership**: you own and can defend every line; you sign the DCO. Don't use maintainers as an LLM validation service.
- **Zero-tolerance for hallucinations**: PRs with non-existent APIs / config keys are closed immediately.
- **Disclosure**: state clearly if an LLM generated structural code, tests, or docs.
- **No LLM-dump**: write a concise, human-authored PR description and review replies.

AI Policy — Responsible Workflow

1. Confirm the issue is valid; discuss the approach on the thread first.
2. Run the code locally — it **compiles, lints, and passes tests**.
3. Read your own diff line-by-line; remove verbose AI comments and cruft.
4. Explain the change in plain technical language yourself.

> "Maintainers want to talk to you, the author — not to your chatbot."

Contributing to ROS 2 Documentation

- Source lives in ros2/ros2_documentation.
- Built with **Sphinx**; pages in **reStructuredText** or **Markdown**.
- Branch per distribution: `rolling`, `jazzy`, `humble` ...
- Same fork → branch → **DCO-signed** commit → PR flow as code.

Docs — Build & Preview Locally

```
git clone https://github.com/ros2/ros2_documentation.git
cd ros2_documentation
pip install -r requirements.txt
make html
# open build/html/index.html
```

- Preview locally before opening the PR.
- CI builds the site and runs link / style checks on your branch.

Docs — Dev Container

- ros2/ros2_documentation ships a **Dev Container** for a reproducible, zero-setup toolchain.
- Open in **VS Code** → **"Reopen in Container"** (or GitHub Codespaces); it provisions Python, Sphinx, and all `requirements.txt` deps automatically.
- Same `make html` build inside the container — no host pollution, identical to CI.

```
// .devcontainer/devcontainer.json (excerpt)
{
  "image": "mcr.microsoft.com/devcontainers/python:3",
  "postCreateCommand": "pip install -r requirements.txt"
}
```

Docs — Test

Before opening the PR, run the same checks CI runs — locally or inside the Dev Container.

```
make test          # rst style / whitespace (doc8)
make lint          # reStructuredText linter (sphinx-lint)
make spellcheck    # spell check prose (codespell)
make linkcheck     # detect broken internal / external links
make test-tools    # python tooling tests (pytest)
```

- Add legitimately-flagged words to `codespell_whitelist.txt`, and custom corrections to `codespell_dictionary.txt` — then `make check-dictionaries` / `make sort-dictionaries`.
- Sphinx builds with `-W`, so **warnings are errors**; a clean local run ≈ a green CI run.

Summary — Getting Started Checklist

- [ ] Fork, clone, add `upstream`
- [ ] `vcs import` the source, `rosdep install` deps
- [ ] `colcon build` + `colcon test` green locally
- [ ] Topic branch, focused **DCO-signed** commits
- [ ] Fill issue/PR templates; disclose AI use
- [ ] Pass Jenkins CI on all platforms
- [ ] Engage reviewers as the author

References

- ROS 2 Developer Guide
- Contributing To ROS 2 Documentation
- Code Style and Language Versions
- ci.ros2.org / colcon
- AI-Assisted Contributions Guidelines